

Episode 136: Once Upon a Time... 80 – Into the Turbulent Year 1995: Again From *Dragon Ball Z* Movie

As a child, I loved doing fireworks with my family in our yard on summer evenings. When I was a child, fireworks were sold individually at nearby shopping districts. Now various types of fireworks are bundled into packages sold at supermarkets and toy stores, but back then—what kind of shops were they? In summer, shops would display fireworks out front for sale. Ones that made flames go whoosh, ones that crackled and sparked with light. Since we did fireworks in a garden small as a cat's forehead, we didn't choose big elaborate ones like those you launch, but I'd still excitedly select extremely modest handheld fireworks and have mother buy them.

Sometimes I'd get ones you hang under eaves and light. Those waterfalls of light were beautiful. Morning glories and pond surfaces illuminated by that light remain in my memories even now.

Even at this age, I think every year about wanting to do fireworks like those days, but it doesn't quite work out. First, the sight of a middle-aged man doing fireworks alone is, from others' perspectives, a bit... you know (laugh).

Still, I think maybe sparklers would be okay, but when I tried sparklers a few years back on some occasion, they were incomparably shabby compared to old ones, leaving me disappointed.

Somewhere, aren't there proper sparklers like we used to do, with gunpowder right up close to where you hold them? If you search properly, are they still sold? Such old-fashioned sparklers.

Thinking such things, I noticed cicada voices growing distant, and cricket autumn voices became audible at night. While still quite hot during the day, mornings and evenings have become much more bearable recently.

Ah, this year's summer is ending too. Thinking that makes me feel lonely.

Now then.

1994 ended with *Pretty Soldier Sailor Moon S* movie and OVA *Warriors of Erosion*. In the usual flow, after completing one theatrical work I'd have a break from work and get some extended rest, but *Sailor Moon S* movie completed in mid-November, then *Warriors of Erosion* work continued for year-end delivery, so 1994 was unusually work until year's very end.

With *Warriors of Erosion* in full production swing in early December, my next job also started. One instalment of next year's March "Spring Break Toei Anime Fair"—*Dragon Ball Z Movie: Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta*. Director: Yamauchi Shigeyasu, Script: Koyama Takao, Animation Director: Yamamuro Tadayoshi, Art Setting: Kubota Tadao, Art Director: Tokushige Masaru.

This was my fifth *Dragon Ball Z* theatrical work. While the previous work had me getting tired of *Dragon Ball Z* making motivation difficult to maintain (wry laugh), maybe having *Sailor Moon S* and such in between was good? I was a forward-thinking, motivated me thinking "Alright! Let's work hard!" (I think having Yamauchi-san as director was actually most significant (laugh)).

This story was set in the demon world. A mass of people's soul evil thoughts combines with young red demon to become monster Janemba, reviving the dead one after another and throwing the world into chaos. Goku and Vegeta, revived by Janemba, join forces to fight Janemba.

Director Yamauchi's storyboard work continued until after New Year's I think, but setting-related work was progressing rapidly from early December. First, confirming TV series *Dragon Ball Z* story progress and settings.

Theatrical *Dragon Ball Z* episodes fit between ongoing TV series timeline. So characters who appeared and were active on TV also appear in theatrical versions following that flow. For example, Gohan's Great Saiyaman, Mr. Satan, No. 18, Videl and such. Since I mostly hadn't watched TV series broadcasts (wry laugh), everyone had appeared without my knowledge, and before starting theatrical work I always had "who's this?" exchanges with TV staff.

Plus one more important TV series coordination aspect: child character growth. Gohan had grown up quite a while ago, but his brother Goten and Vegeta's son Trunks were actually subtly growing in height by design. Krillin with changed hairstyle too (laugh). Like that, checking TV series settings was essential. Oh, and dead characters! Since Goku and Pikkon are dead, they get "halos" on their heads (laugh).

Characters appearing in TV series naturally have character designs drawn for TV, but they're actually redrawn anew for each theatrical version. TV designs were drawn by Nakatsuru-san I believe, but theatrical versions have been handled by Yamamuro-san as animation director for several works now. Yamamuro-san's animation was quite different from TV, especially "shadow" animation volume feeling differed from TV.

Character colours change impression considerably based on shadow volume. Even painted with same colour direction, they can look completely different depending on shadow and highlight area ratios and application. Or depending on shadow application methods, changing significantly from colour direction often looked better. Especially for special animation like Super Saiyans.

So at my request, TV series characters also had designs rewritten by Yamamuro-san wherever possible. For this *Fusion Reborn!! Goku and Vegeta*: Goku, Pikkon, King Yemma, King Kai and others. Gohan, Videl, Goten, Trunks used Yamamuro-san rewrites from previous works. And naturally, colours also had theatrical volume added.

Then, theatrical original characters.

Theatrical enemy characters would have rough (!) sketches arrive from original creator Toriyama, organised for anime according to story, but this time I remember Toriyama gave OK to designs exactly as Yamamuro-san designed based on Director Yamauchi's ideas. I created colours for those designs.

Janemba had two designs. First was the early innocent child-like, fluffy round Janemba. A seemingly comical atmosphere design that actually didn't look very strong, so I aimed for that feeling and unified it in overall cream-coloured soft tones.

The second Janemba was pure evil, incredibly strong imagery appearing in the latter half. Sharp eyes, sharp form—clearly a powerful enemy! design. So definitely strong red and purple. Trying various options, I settled on red and purple after all.

After passing Shueisha checks and progressing through poster and trailer work, 1994 ended. And finally 1995, Heisei 7.

At that year's start, something tremendous literally shook the Japanese archipelago.

(10.09.14)